

## Exercise 1 – Alien Anthropologist

One of the central aims of design is to question the assumptions we make about the objects, systems and interfaces that surround us. Many interactions feel "natural" not because they are inherently intuitive, but because we have learned them over years of repetition. Today, your task is to make the familiar strange.

Working in pairs, choose one everyday object or interface from around the classroom or campus. Now imagine you're an anthropologist from outer space and create a short 3-4 minute documentary video in which you encounter this "human" object for the very first time, with no prior knowledge of what it is or what it's for.

Treat it as a genuine ethnographic investigation, and focus on behaviour, interaction and observation. Your job isn't to explain the object—it's to observe it. How do humans approach it? What do they touch? What seems to happen? What assumptions are they making?

Don't name the object. Don't simply explain its function. You may not use words such as "button", "door", "chair", "phone", "screen", "switch", "person", or any conventional object names. Describe only what you observe.